

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

25 April 2013

To the Delegates to the Eleventh International Bahá'í Convention

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

At this joyful season, it brings us great happiness to extend to you a loving welcome upon your arrival in the Holy Land to attend the Eleventh International Bahá'í Convention. Those of you gathered here in person—representing an anticipated 156 countries or territories—are joined in spirit by delegates from a number of other countries, whose circumstances allow them to participate only by sending their ballots. We are delighted that your ranks are now fortified by members of the National Spiritual Assemblies of Afghanistan, Burundi, Côte d'Ivoire, Korea, Lesotho and Vietnam—Assemblies that were able to re-form in the past five years, some after the lapse of decades.

Soon after your arrival, you will have the bounty of visiting those holy precincts to which the hearts of Bahá'ís worldwide turn each day. In those blessed surroundings, with your thoughts fixed steadfastly on the Abhá Beauty and with your faces set towards the wonders of His Kingdom, your souls will be refreshed through the outpourings of His benevolence and grace. With sanctified spirits and in a rarefied atmosphere of purity and detachment, you will then gather on the first morning of the Convention to discharge, in a manner far, far removed from the prevailing standards of elections in the world, your sacred responsibility of electing the Universal House of Justice.

The consultative sessions provide you, as the chosen representatives of the Bahá'í world, with the precious opportunity to consider together the vital issues facing the Cause at this time and to share experience from the field. The present stage of the Divine Plan will be at the heart of these deliberations, with separate topics designated for each of the various sessions. You may, however, after due reflection, bring forward additional matters that you feel are essential to the progress and well-being of the Faith.

An audio-visual presentation *Frontiers of Learning*, which will be shown on the second day of the Convention, provides glimpses of the dynamic spirit animating the endeavours of the friends and the experience being gained in four clusters across the world. In addition, a document entitled *Insights from the Frontiers of Learning*, which we hope you will be able to peruse in the days preceding the Convention, has been provided as part of your registration package to assist you in your contributions to the consultations.

As you visit the Holy Places during your brief stay here, you will witness what the Bahá'í world has achieved at its World Centre over the past five years. Crowning these accomplishments is the restoration of the Shrine of the Báb, whose golden dome once again shines out in full splendour. Other developments include the renovation of the House of the Master and the International Archives Building; restoration and conservation of the Ridván Garden, designated by Bahá'u'lláh as “Our Verdant Isle”; and completion of the perimeter path surrounding the Most Holy Shrine.

May your supplications in the Holy Shrines inspire your souls and prepare you for the sacred responsibility with which you are entrusted. And following these few days, which

will swiftly pass, may you arise with renewed strength and clarity of vision to offer your share to the spiritual enterprise in which the worldwide Bahá'í community is so devotedly engaged.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]